

The Shattered Covenant: Black Barrow Keep's Fall

A Fate's Edge Adventure for Tiers IV-V (Paragon to Mythic)

1 Core Premise: The Tragedy That Broke the World

Centuries ago, **King Lagan the Unyielding**—a mortal ruler of Payden's Port—commissioned the Aelinnel (gnome) craftsmen of Black Barrow Keep to forge not just servants, but a **Covenant Heart**: a self-winding engine meant to *guarantee* his lineage's eternal rule through perfect, unbreakable oaths forged in brass and blood. He believed: *Mortal vows fade. Machine oaths endure.*

But the Aelinnel, wary of binding souls to cold perfection, wove a hidden clause into the Heart's gears: **True oaths require breath, not just tick.** When Lagan activated it, the Heart didn't enshrine his power—it *shattered*. The Covenant wasn't with the king—it was with the *Barrow itself*, a slumbering entity older than men. Enraged, Lagan tried to seize the Heart... and the Aelinnel servants, their souls bound to the Barrow's will via the Heart's flaw, turned on him.

What happened next:

- The servants didn't just kill Lagan's family—they became *hosts*. As they slaughtered the royal line, whispers slithered into their brass veins: *demons* drawn to the Heart's broken covenant, seeking to wear flesh and steel as new bodies.
- Lagan's last act was to seal the upper keep—not to trap threats *in*, but to lock the demon-hosts *out* of the catacombs, where the Barrow's true heart slept.
- Now, the Mist has seeped through the seals. The demon-hosts stalk the upper floors, their movements jerky, their eyes glowing with hellfire. Below, the Barrow's dead—kings, servants, oath-breakers—are stirring, kissed by Mist-Wraiths that carry the **Echo of the Mist King**: a forgotten monarch whose compulsion bends the dead to his will.
- **The Bell Line fails** not from neglect, but because the Mist King's Echo *drowns* the wards' living rhythm. Repairing it requires either:

- (A) *Silencing the Covenant Heart* (stopping the demon threat upstairs), **AND**
- (B) *Facing the Mist King* in the catacombs (to still his Echo or break his hold).

The road remembers. Every broken wheel leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness. The only question is: what are you willing to owe?

And sometimes... the heaviest debt is the one you owe to the king who tried to outlive his mortality. —Adapted from Dusana of the Raven Road, The Hearth Ledger

2 Why This Fits Fate's Edge

Fate's Edge Principle	How This Adventure Embodies It
Narrative First	Every roll ties to the tragedy: Position shifts reflect whether you're <i>in step</i> with the Mist King's Echo (Dominant = you resist his pull; Desperate = his rhythm owns you). Harm from wraiths clears Fatigue—but the mist's chill seeps back faster, creating desperate cycles.
Risk Creates Drama	Magic risks backlash <i>and</i> demonic temptation (e.g., a Freecaster's spell might work—but the Covenant Heart tries to <i>tune</i> your soul to its rhythm, marking Obligation). Combat risks precise Harm from gear-traps (ignoring armor) <i>or</i> soul-sapping touch from the undead.
Meaningful Growth	Tier IV-V choices have legacy weight: Spend XP to fortify a refuge (Asset) <i>or</i> train a successor (Follower) who might one day face the Barrow's next awakening. Clearing Obligation to the Barrow requires Acts of Service honoring <i>imperfection</i> (e.g., leaving a task unfinished).
Consequences Matter	Failing to silence the Heart doesn't just mean more fights—it advances the Demon Timer (more hosts awaken). Ignoring the Mist King advances the Echo Timer (more dead rise, Barrow's corruption spreads). Success isn't <i>winning</i> —it's choosing <i>what kind of scar you leave on the world</i> .
Modular Design	Run core mystery (Session 1) → mechanical gauntlet (Session 2) → catacombs approach (Session 3) → climax (Session 4). Layer in magic (Ch. 5), Assets/Followers (Ch. 12), and Legacy Engine (Ch. 19) as XP and story demand.

3 Adventure Structure (4 Sessions)

The Mist's advance serves as a dual-layer timer: upstairs, the Demon Timer ticks as hosts awaken; downstairs, the Echo Timer swells as the Mist King's influence grows.

3.1 Session 1: The Ashes of Lagan's Line (Investigation & Stakes)

Hook: Players arrive in Payden's Port as mist thickens like wet wool. Refugees whisper of *brass-handed things* in the keep's ruins and dreams of a *crown of fog* commanding the dead.

Key Locations:

- **The Salt Docks:** Mist clings to cobblestones, revealing *half-melted brass figurines* (Aelinnel craftsmanship) and *scorch marks* like branding irons.

- *Investigation (Wits+Lore, DV 3):* Success = find a child's shoe fused to a gear fragment (proof of the massacre). Partial = gain 1 Boon, but notice salt crystals *avoiding* the scorch marks (unnatural repulsion).
- *Creative Use:* Spirit+Insight (DV 4) to sense the lingering terror—gain +1 die vs. fear effects here (you *feel* the injustice).

- **The Refugee Camp:** A traumatized Aelinnel tinkerer (missing an eye, replaced with a cloudy glass orb) mumbles:

*We built the Heart to serve **life**—not to be a cage for **hunger**. When the king tried to rip it free... the Barrow **answered**. The servants... they weren't **ours** anymore.*

- *Social (Presence+Sway, DV 4):* Success = learn the Heart's flaw (it *rejects* pure mechanical oaths; needs *breath in the brass*). Failure = he attacks in despair (Harm 1; Desperate Position).
- **The Legate's Hall:** Stone hall where Mistlander elders debate sealing the keep *permanently* (fire, collapse) vs. risking entry.
 - *Social (Presence+Command, DV 5):* Success = convince them to *delay* sealing (gain time to investigate); Failure = they begin preparations, advancing the **Seal-The-Doom Timer** (if full, they collapse the keep's entrance—trapping anyone inside).

Mechanical Focus:

- **Position as Moral Weight:** Near the docks, mist feels *heavy with unresolved guilt*—Spirit-based actions gain +1 die (resonance with the tragedy) but risk +1 SB on failure (the Barrow’s sorrow lashes back).
- **Story Beats (SB):** GM spends SB to reveal tragic details:
 - 1 SB: A child’s laughter echoes in the mist—then cuts off abruptly.
 - 2 SB: The scorch marks on the docks form a faint, fading sigil: *Aelinnel knot of broken trust*.
 - 3 SB: A wraith-like shape flows *uphill* toward the keep—carrying a tiny, tarnished crown.

Cliffhanger: At dusk, the Mist parts briefly—revealing Black Barrow Keep’s silhouette. From a shattered upper window, a single brass hand *twitches* in the fog... then stills.

3.2 Session 2: The Brass Gauntlet (Upper Floors – Demon-Hosts & the Covenant Heart)

Hook: Players choose how to enter:

- **The Salt Causeway** (narrow path; requires Athletics+Survival vs. DV 4 to avoid oil-slicked stones *and* pressure plates that trigger grinding gear-traps).
- **The Refugee’s Ladder** (rope ascent through shattered shantytowns; risks drawing hosts to civilians; Social: Command+Presence vs. DV 3 to route civilians safely).

Key Locations:

- **The Shattered Atrium:** Once a grand hall, now choked with *demon-hosts*—humanoid figures in tattered livery, joints jerking unnaturally, eyes glowing with sickly green fire. They don’t *see*—they *sense rhythm* (heartbeats, breath).
 - *Threat:* Harm 2 per hit (their claws are superheated brass); ignores non-magic armor.
 - *Position Shift:* Flanking isn’t just tactical—it’s *breaking their sync*. Success = they stutter (lose next action); Failure = they anticipate you (gain +1 die vs. you).
 - *Weakness:* Loud, irregular noises (e.g., smashing pottery) impose -1 die on their attacks (Disperse their sense of rhythm).

- **The Workshop Corridors:** Aelinnel craftsmanship twisted—workbenches hold *half-assembled hosts*, gears exposed and sparking.
 - *Clockwork Trap:* Pressure plates trigger *whirring saw-blades* (DV 3 Athletics to dodge; Failure = Harm 1 + gain 1 Exposure [the Heart notices your rhythm]).
 - *Creative Combo (Wits+Craft):* Success = jury-rig a gear-jam to delay a trap (gain 1 Boon for next Athletics roll).
- **The Covenant Heart Chamber:** The throne room’s center holds the **Heart**—a pulsing, brass sphere the size of a man’s head, veins of molten silver tracing its surface. Around it, demon-hosts stand rigidly still... *waiting*.
 - *The Heart’s Temptation:* It doesn’t attack—it *offers*.
 - * *Mechanic:* When a player takes an action here, the Heart whispers: *Let me steady your hand. Let me still your fear.*
 - *Accept (Spend 1 Boon):* Gain +2 dice to the action... but mark **1 Obligation segment to the Heart** (track separately).
 - *Refuse:* No immediate cost, but the Heart’s whisper lingers—gain 1 Fatigue (the strain of resisting its *help*).
 - * *Clearing Heart-Obligation:* Requires an Act of Service celebrating *imperfect effort* (e.g., *I deliberately miss this gear-tooth on purpose, letting the scrape be uneven*). Success = clear 1 Obligation segment.
 - * *Silencing the Heart (The Key Step):* **Not a single roll**—a multi-step process requiring specific skills:
 1. *Understand the Flaw* (Lore+Arcana, DV 5): Success = learn the Heart needs *breath in the brass* to stabilize (i.e., introduce *imperfection*).
 2. *Introduce the Flaw* (Craft+Survival, DV 6): Success = jam a foreign, *organic* object into its veins (e.g., a salt-crystal soaked in refugee tears, a living sprig of mistland moss).
 - *Critical Twist:* If the object isn’t *truly* imperfect (e.g., a perfect gear-tooth), the Heart *rejects it violently*—gears spew molten brass (Harm 2 to all Near).
 - *Success:* The Heart seizes—not destroyed, but *stalled*. Demon-hosts jerk violently... then collapse into inert brass husks.
 - *Cost:* The stall is temporary. Every time you *clear Fatigue* via [HEAL] or rest, the Heart gains 1 “*Tick*” (it tries to restart). At 5 Ticks, it

jolts back to life (advance the **Demon Timer** by 1 segment; hosts begin to twitch).

Mechanical Focus:

- **Obligation as Temptation:** The Heart's offer isn't free power—it's a *debt* that makes you *more* like it (Ch. 5.3.1 Obligation Overflow = Fatigue). Clearing it requires roleplaying humility (Ch. 15.5.2 Off-Screen Clearing).
- **Harm/Fatigue Roller-Coaster:** Host attacks deal Harm 2 (clearing all Fatigue per Ch. 2.10.2)—but the mist's chill seeps in *faster* after, making recovery harder. Describe: *The host's claws sear your arm—white-hot agony floods your veins. You gasp, not from pain, but from the sudden absence of the bone-deep dread that's clung to you since the docks. Your vision sharpens... then the mist's whispers crawl back in, colder than before.*
- **Story Beats (SB):** GM spends SB to reveal the hosts' tragedy:
 - 1 SB: A host's jaw works silently—*forming the word **sorry*** before seizing again.
 - 2 SB: Green fire flickers in one host's eyes—revealing a *human iris* beneath the demon-glow.
 - 3 SB: The Heart's pulse stutters—for 3 seconds, it matches *your* resting heart rate.

Cliffhanger: As the last host collapses, the Mist in the chamber *parts*—revealing a staircase spiraling *down* into blackness. From below, a sound like *wet stone grinding on stone...* and a voice like wind through tombs: *You silenced my jailers... but you did not silence me.*

3.3 Session 3: The Echoing Deep (Catacombs Approach – Awakening Dead & the Mist King)

Hook: The staircase descends into catacombs carved from living stone, walls veined with *frozen mist* that pulses faintly blue. The air tastes of ozone and old blood.

Key Locations:

- **The Whispering Vaults:** Niches hold sarcophagi laced with silver—*not* for decoration, but to *contain*. Lids are slightly askew.

- *Threat*: Mist-Wraiths (wisps of screaming fog) drift between tombs. Touch = Harm 1 [Mental] + gain 1 Fatigue.
- *Awakening the Dead*: Roll Wits+Survival (DV 4) to avoid disturbing a sarcophagus.
 - * *Failure*: Lid bursts open—*animated corpse* rises (Harm 1 per hit; ignores non-magic armor).
 - * *Critical Detail*: These aren't mindless zombies. They move with eerie precision, *turning* to face you as one—**the Mist King's Echo is syncing them.**
 - * *Creative Use*: Spirit+Performance (DV 4) to *sing a counter-lullaby* → wraiths falter for 1 round (advantage on next action).
- **The Hall of Oaths**: A long corridor where walls are etched with *oaths in Aelinne's ledger-script*—names of kings, servants, oath-breakers. The carvings are *fresh*, as if rewritten recently.
 - *Social (Presence+Command, DV 5)*: Success = read the oaths' true meaning (they're *not* vows—they're *pleas*: *Remember me. Do not let me be forgotten.*).
 - * *Success*: Gain +2 dice vs. Mental Harm here (you understand the dead's hunger).
 - * *Failure*: The words seem to *shift* as you read—gain 1 Harm [Mental] (the Echo is probing your mind).
 - *Obligation Mechanic*: The Barrow tracks your *respect for the dead*.
 - * *Gain 1 Obligation segment*: If you desecrate a tomb (e.g., loot without words) or speak ill of the dead.
 - * *Clear 1 Obligation segment*: Act of Service honoring the forgotten (e.g., *I press my forehead to this cold lid and whisper the name I imagine they bore*).
- **The Mist King's Audience Chamber**: A vast, domed room. At its center: a throne of black stone, empty... but the air *shimmers* where a crown should be. Mist pools here like liquid shadow, coiling and uncoiling in slow, hypnotic patterns.
 - *The Mist King's Echo*: Not a ghost—but a **resonance** in the Barrow's stone, a memory of compulsion so strong it bends the dead to its will.
 - * *Effect*: All undead in the Barrow gain +1 die to attacks *and* ignore non-magic armor (they move with unnatural unity).
 - * *Social Challenge (Ch. 7.12.2)*: To resist or influence the King:

1. *Phase 1 (Wits+Investigation, DV 4)*: Sense the Echo's rhythm in the mist. Success = gain insight (you feel its "*pulse*"); Failure = gain 1 Harm [Mental] (the Echo stutters your thoughts).
2. *Phase 2 (Presence+Command, DV 5)*: Attempt to *reason* with the Echo or *defy* its pull.
 - *Success (Persuade)*: Gain +3 dice vs. undead effects for 1 hour (the Echo hesitates, confused by your voice).
 - *Success (Defy)*: Gain +2 dice to all rolls vs. Barrow threats (you stand *off-beat* to its rhythm).
 - *Failure*: The Echo *locks* onto you—must spend 2 Boons to avoid Harm 3 (your thoughts stutter like a broken record).

Mechanical Focus:

- **Position as Rhythmic War**: At Tier V, Position isn't just survival—it's whether you're *in step* with the Mist King's Echo.
 - *Desperate*: Your breath hitches—*inhale... exhale... inhale*—*matching the mist's pull. You are becoming its voice.*
 - *Dominant*: You stand *off-beat*. The mist coils, confused. For now, you are not its echo.
- **Story Beats (SB)**: GM spends SB to reveal the King's tragedy:
 - 1 SB: A wraith's shape resolves into a child's face—*mouth*ing a name you almost recognize.
 - 2 SB: The mist forms a fleeting crown... then dissolves into weeping.
 - 3 SB: The throne feels *warm* to the touch—for 3 seconds, like stone left in sunlight.

Cliffhanger: As you approach the throne, the Mist parts—revealing *a void* where the crown should be. From it, a whisper like ice cracking: *I was forgotten first. Let the world remember... or let it end.*

3.4 Session 4: The King's Choice (Climax – Repairing the Bell Line)

Hook: The Mist King's Echo isn't a being to destroy—it's a *wound* in the Barrow's soul. Repairing the Bell Line requires addressing *why* he was forgotten.

Key Choices:

- **Option A: Defy the Echo (Combat)**

- *Mechanic:* Engage the Echo as a *Social Challenge* (Ch. 7.12.2) with escalating stakes:

1. *Round 1 (Wits+Investigation, DV 5):* Find the Echo’s “*weak point*” (a memory of when he was first slighted). Success = gain +2 dice vs. him; Failure = he gains 1 Tick (advances Echo Timer).
2. *Round 2 (Presence+Command, DV 6):* Either:
 - * (A) *Shatter His Will:* Deal “*social Harm*” (Ch. 15.8.3.5 Full Ritual). Success = Echo flickers—advance **Seal Timer** by 2 segments (Bell Line begins to heal). Failure = he counters—gain 1 Harm [Mental] + Echo Timer advances 2 segments.
 - * (B) *Bind His Will:* Attempt to *contain* him (not destroy). Success = Echo stabilizes—gain +1 die vs. Barrow threats *permanently* (but you mark 1 permanent Obligation to the Barrow; clearing it requires Acts of Service *remembering* the forgotten). Failure = he breaks free—Harm 3 + Echo Timer full (Barrow floods with awakened dead).
3. *Risk:* If Echo Timer fills *before* you succeed, the Barrow’s dead rise *en masse*—you must flee or be overwhelmed (Harm 2 per round until escape).

- **Option B: Remember the Forgotten (Persuasion)**

- *Mechanic:* Perform an *Act of Service* so profound it addresses the King’s core wound:

To stand between the forgotten and the remembered, and give voice to the voiceless.

- * *Requires:*

1. *Find His Name* (Lore+Investigation, DV 6): Search the Hall of Oaths for a *deleted* oath (scratched over, but traces remain). Success = recover his true name (e.g., *King Vorlag the Unmourned*).
2. *Give Him Voice* (Presence+Performance or Spirit+Lore, DV 7): Speak his name *into the Mist Pool* in the Audience Chamber, telling one true thing about him (not a lie to flatter—the *truth*, even if painful).
 - *Success:* The Mist Pool stills. The Echo doesn’t vanish—it *changes*. Gain +3 dice vs. Barrow threats *and* the Bell Line flares to life (mist recedes, wraiths dissipate).

- *Failure*: The mist rejects your words—gain 1 Harm [Mental] + the Echo grows hungrier (Echo Timer advances 2 segments).
- * *Cost*: Even on success, the Barrow remembers its pain. Clearing its Obligation requires regular Acts of Service: *I tell a story where the hero fails—and I honor the try.*

Resolution Paths:

- **The Bell Line Heals (Partial Success)**: You stall the Echo *or* give the King voice—but not both. Mist recedes from Payden’s Port... but lingers in the Barrow’s depths.
 - *Cost*: The Barrow remains a weakly sealed wound. Every full moon, mist seeps outward (advance a **Moon Timer** ; if full, repeat Session 3 threats).
 - *Legacy*: If players retreat, a Follower they saved returns years later, seeking to *finish* the work—offering a Legacy Bond (once/session: gain +1 die when acting to preserve forgotten histories).
- **The Covenant is Renewed (Full Success)**: You both stall the Echo *AND* give the King voice. The Bell Line flares *stronger* than before—mist becomes a *tool*, not a threat (e.g., salt-mist reveals hidden paths).
 - *Cost*: The Covenant Heart isn’t destroyed—it’s *reborn*. It now ticks in time with the Barrow’s living breath... but demands tribute. Clearing its Obligation requires Acts of Service *honoring imperfect oaths* (e.g., *I swear to try—and I will fail, and I will try again*).
 - *Legacy*: The Barrow becomes a place of pilgrimage. Scholars come to study its “*living wards*”—and players might be called to defend it from those who would exploit its power.
- **The Barrow Hungers (Failure)**: You anger the Echo *and* fail to remember the King. The Mist King’s wrath peaks—he doesn’t just awaken the dead; he *unmakes* the Barrow’s seals.
 - *Cost*: The keep begins to sink into the earth. Players must escape (Chase Scene: Athletics+Acrobatics vs. DV 6 per round; failure = Harm 2 + trapped). Payden’s Port is abandoned; the mist claims the ruins.
 - *Legacy*: Refugees whisper of a “*king who walks beneath the stones*”—and someday, someone will try to wake him *on purpose*.

4 Mechanical Deep Dive: Fate's Edge Integration

Element	Rule Reference	How This Adventure Uses It
Obligation	Ch. 5.3.1 (Capacity = Spirit+Presence)	Heart's Count (Ticks from clearing Fatigue) = passive Obligation tracker; Mist King's Obligation (from disrespecting dead) cleared via Acts of Service honoring the forgotten (Ch. 15.5.2). Both mirror Patron mechanics but tied to the Barrow's tragedy.
Harm/Fatigue Roller-Coaster	Ch. 2.10.2 (Taking Harm clears Fatigue)	Wraith/host attacks deal Harm that clears Fatigue—but the Barrow's corruption (mist chill, Echo's pull) seeps back <i>faster</i> , creating desperate cycles where players <i>need</i> to take a wound to think straight... only to feel the dread return stronger.
Position as Narrative Weight	Ch. 7.8.6 (Position scales with Tier)	At Tier V, Position reflects <i>rhythmic alignment</i> : <i>Desperate</i> : In sync with the Barrow's hunger (you're becoming what it wants). <i>Dominant</i> : Off-beat (you resist its pull, but it's exhausting). This makes Position a <i>story-telling tool</i> , not just a mechanic.
Story Beats (SB)	Ch. 2.9 (GM spends SB for complications)	SB spent to reveal <i>tragedy</i> , not <i>just threats</i> : 1 SB: A detail of the massacre (a child's toy, a lover's last note). 2 SB: A glimpse of the King's humanity (his hands shaking as he signed the Heart's pact). 3 SB: The Echo's true pain (he wasn't evil—he was <i>terrified</i> of being forgotten).
Creative Skill Use	Ch. 7.3.2 (GM guidance for creative pairs)	Rewards <i>Aelinnel ingenuity</i> and <i>Mistlen den wisdom</i> .

5 Tier-Appropriate Threats & Rewards

5.1 Threats (Scaled for Tier IV-V)

Threat	Tier IV Effect	Tier V Effect
Demon-Hosts (brass-jawed)	Harm 2 per hit; ignores light armor	Harm 3 per hit; ignores <i>all</i> non-magic armor
Mist-Wraiths	Harm 1 [Mental] + 1 Fatigue on touch	Harm 2 [Mental] + 2 Fatigue; grants +1 Exposure
Covenant Heart's Temptation	On accepted Boon: +1 Obligation segment	On accepted Boon: +2 Obligation segments
Mist King's Echo	On failed Social: +1 Harm [Mental]	On failed Social: +2 Harm [Mental] + Echo Timer advances
Narrative Purpose	Test if players rely on armor or adapt to <i>precision</i> threats (Ch. 20.1.1). Make “scouting” risky—reinforces mist as active enemy (Ch. 16.4). Make the “easy” power <i>temptingly costly</i> (Ch. 5.3.4 Hard Choice). Force players to <i>engage</i> the narrative, not just roll dice (Ch. 7.11.3).	

5.2 Rewards (Treasure as Leverage - Ch. 17.2)

- **Minor:** A **tear-soaked salt crystal** (once/session: clear 1 Fatigue when performing an Act of Service for the forgotten).
- **Standard:** The **King's Last Letter** (scorched but readable):

Spend 1 Boon to activate: For 1 hour, you gain +1 die vs. Barrow threats AND the Mist King's Echo cannot gain Ticks from you.

But: After use, roll d6: on 1, gain 1 permanent Corruption segment (the weight of his regret lingers).

- **Major:** The **Aelinnel Ledger of Broken Oaths** (massive brass book):

*Open to a random page: Read an oath the Barrow demands you **break** to prove your sincerity (e.g., “Swear you will never return here”).*

If you break it sincerely: Gain +2 dice to all rolls vs. Barrow threats for 1 day + clear 1 Obligation segment to the Barrow.

If you break it flippantly: Gain 1 Harm [Mental] + the Barrow marks you as oath-breaker (advance Echo Timer 1 segment).

5.3 Legacy Seeds (Ch. 19)

- **If players heal the Barrow (Partial/Full Success):**
 - The Covenant Heart now requires **regular “imperfection oaths”** to stay stable (e.g., *I swear to try—and I will fail, and I will try again*). Clearing its Obligation: Act of Service celebrating a *beautiful flaw* (e.g., *I baked bread that burnt—and I shared it anyway*).
 - A refugee child they saved returns years later, apprenticed to an Aelinnel tinkerer, seeking to *tune* the Heart—not to stop it, but to *dance* with its rhythm.
- **If players fail to heal the Barrow:**
 - The Barrow’s sinking creates a **new mist-choked valley** where refugees whisper of the “Walking King.”
 - Their Follower (if any) inherits a Legacy Bond: Once/session, gain +1 die when acting to *prevent forgetting* (e.g., visiting a grave, telling a story of the fallen).
- **The Mist King’s True Legacy:**
 - Even if “defeated,” his Echo isn’t gone—it’s *transformed*.
 - On Full Success: His presence becomes a **guardian of memory** (once/session: gain +1 die when acting to honor the forgotten).
 - On Partial Success: He lingers as a **warning** (once/session: gain +1 die vs. threats that seek to erase history).

6 GM Guidance: Running the Barrow’s Tragedy

- **Describe the *Rhythm* First:** Before every roll, note the Barrow’s pulse:
 - *Near salt (upstairs):* The *faint tick-tick* of stalled gears (safe for now—Heart is stalled).
 - *In the Whispering Vaults:* Mist coiling in slow, hypnotic *inhale... exhale...* (sets Position for Mist King’s influence).
 - *Entering the Audience Chamber:* A deep, slow *thoom... thoom...* like a stone giant’s breath.
 - → This sets Position *narratively*: Sync = Desperate (you’re in its rhythm); Off-beat = Dominant (you’re fighting it).

- **Use SB for Emotional Truth:** Don't just spend SB on monsters—spend it on the *humanity beneath the horror*:

- 1 SB: A demon-host's brass finger twitches—*trying to wipe away non-existent tears*.
- 2 SB: The Mist King's Echo forms a fleeting sigh... like a man realizing he's been alone for centuries.
- 3 SB: A sarcophagus lid lifts just enough to reveal a folded, dust-linen shirt inside (a servant's last gift to his child).

- **Embrace the Temptation of Perfection:** When players consider using the Heart's Boon, describe the *allure*:

*The Heart's veins glow under your palms—so close to steady rhythm. For one breath, you feel it: the Barrow isn't a tomb. It's a **promise**. All you have to do is hold this note... and never let go.*

Then hit them with the cost:

*But as you imagine that ease, you see the refugee tinkerer's face—not angry, but **sad**. She's not begging you to stop. She's begging you to **remember** why a promise kept through fear is no promise at all.*

- **Let the Barrow *Remember*:** If players repeatedly use the same tactic (e.g., jamming the Heart with salt), the Barrow *adapts*:
 - After 2 successes, increase DV by 1 (it learns to deflect salt).
 - After 3 successes, it develops a counter (e.g., gear-teeth now *flick* salt away like water off a duck's back).
 - → This forces players to *innovate*, not just repeat (Ch. 7.3.4 WhentoRoll).
- **The True Victory Isn't "Winning":** The Barrow doesn't need to be *destroyed*—it needs to be *understood*. Reward players who:
 - Spend time reading the Hall of Oaths' inscriptions (not just looting).
 - Describe how they *honor* the dead before acting (e.g., *I press my forehead to this lid and whisper the name I imagine they bore*).
 - Choose to *fail* an oath sincerely (per the Ledger of Broken Oaths) to prove their respect.

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And sometimes... the heaviest debt is the one you owe to the silence between heartbeats—the space where forgotten kings wait to be remembered.
Owe it well. Or owe it forever. —Adapted from Dusana of the Raven Road,
The Hearth Ledger*